A Day With Your Wife, Task by Task

A worksheet for the help she needs and what is essential.

“She needs a lot of help” is true, and hard for anyone to work from. “I steady her when she stands up, and I remind her to eat lunch” is something her care team can use.

Take one ordinary day at home, from waking to bed, and write one task per line. Note when the help is needed only where you've seen it yourself; otherwise write “not observed” and leave it. None of this needs a medical word or the name of a place.

The help she gets, one task per line

Start with waking up and go through to bedtime. Name the task, then the kind of help: hands on, standing by, reminding, or doing it for her.

FOR EXAMPLE Getting up from her chair: I steady her by the elbow. Lunch: I put the plate in front of her and remind her to eat.

When you've seen it needed

Beside each task, the times of day or the days you've seen the help needed yourself. If you haven't seen it, write “not observed.” Don't estimate.

FOR EXAMPLE Steadying: mornings, and again after supper when she's tired. Nights: not observed. I'm asleep.

How she gets around and makes herself understood

What she holds or uses to move from room to room, and what helps a conversation with her go well.

FOR EXAMPLE Walker indoors, my arm on the porch steps. She follows better when I ask one thing at a time.

Essential, or a preference?

Go back through your tasks. Mark E beside the help she can't manage without and P beside what would make her days better. Add what matters to her about how she lives, in her words if she can give them.

FOR EXAMPLE E: someone beside her when she stands. P: coffee at six, her own kitchen, the radio on in the afternoon.

Not sure which, and not ours to settle

Anything medical, anything about her medications and anything about supervision goes here, written as a question for her care team.

FOR EXAMPLE Can she be on her own for an hour? We've never tried it, and I don't know who should say.

Who filled this in, and on which days

What this shows you

Three things: the help your wife gets, as plain tasks; which of it you'd call essential; and which questions aren't yours to settle. It doesn't show how much care she needs or what kind of place provides it, and nothing here adds up to a score or a level. How often she needs help beyond what you've seen, and what the next arrangement has to be able to do, are for her care team to confirm.

Ready for the next step?

You've put a day with your wife on paper, one task at a time. The care interview covers the rest: it goes through every area of her daily life, including the ones that don't show up at home, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›